

THE STERN

Puppis



SIZE RANKING 20

BRIGHTEST STAR
Naos (ζ) 2.2

GENITIVE Puppis

ABBREVIATION Pup

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
January–FebruaryFULLY VISIBLE
39°N–90°S

This rich southern constellation straddling the Milky Way was originally part of the ancient Greek constellation of Argo Navis (the ship of Jason and the Argonauts, see p.410) until it was divided into

three parts in the 18th century. Puppis, representing the ship's stern, is the largest part. The stars of each section retained their original Greek letters, and in the case of Puppis the lettering now starts at Zeta (ζ) Puppis, a star that is also known as Naos.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

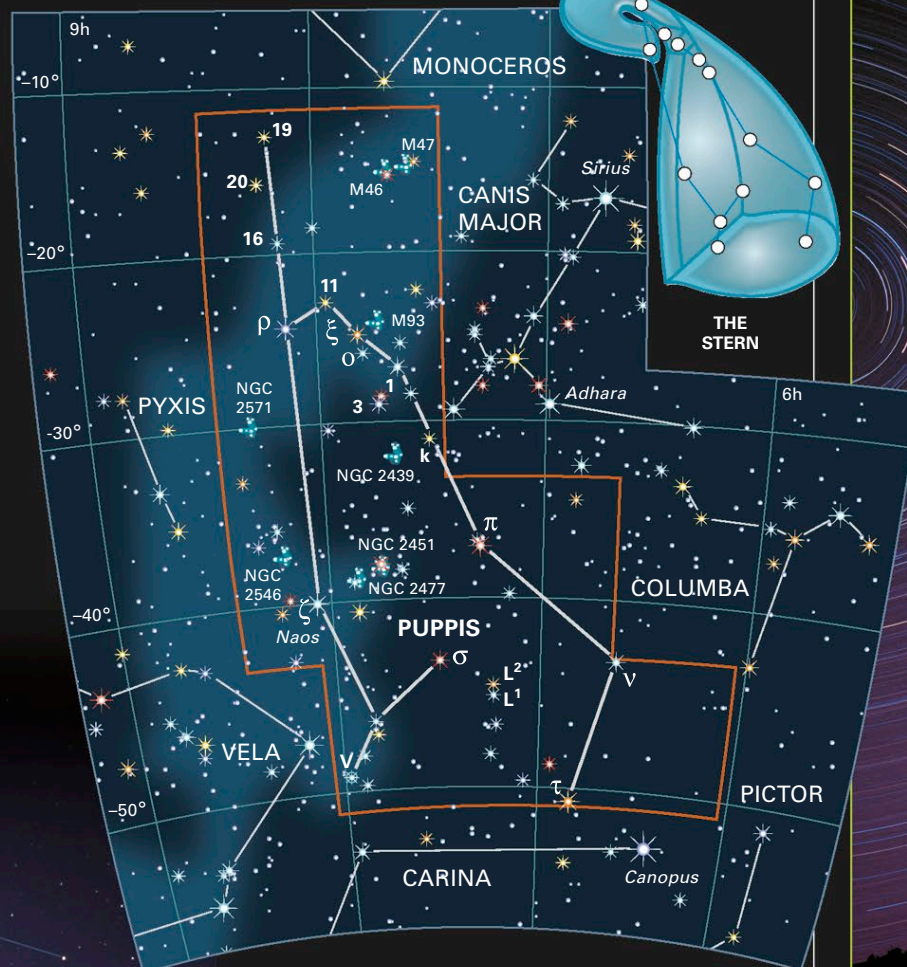
Third-magnitude Xi (ξ) Puppis has a wide and unrelated 5th-magnitude companion that is visible through binoculars, while k Puppis consists of a pair of nearly identical stars with components of 5th magnitude that can be split through a small telescope.

L Puppis is a wide naked-eye and binocular pair, of which L² Puppis is a variable red giant that ranges between 3rd and 6th magnitudes every 5 months or so.

M46 and M47 are a pair of open clusters that together create a brighter patch in the Milky Way. Both appear

of similar size to a full moon. M46 is the richer of the two, while M47 is the closer, being about 1,500 light-years away—that is, less than one-third of the distance of its apparent neighbor. The cluster M93 lies about 3,500 light-years away.

NGC 2477 is an open cluster that looks almost like a globular cluster when seen through binoculars, while NGC 2451 is more scattered and has the 4th-magnitude orange giant ϵ Puppis near its center.



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NGC 2477 π π

This is one of the richest open clusters, containing an estimated 2,000 stars. It is about 4,000 light-years away. The star below NGC-2477 in this picture—b Puppis—is of magnitude 4.5.

STERN OF THE ARGO π π

The stars of Puppis, representing the stern of the *Argo*, are seen here rising behind thin clouds. Sirius (in Canis Major) lies near the left edge of this picture.

SHARP CLUSTER π π

M93 is an attractive open cluster for viewing through binoculars or a small telescope. It is shaped like an arrowhead with two orange giants near its tip.

M46 AND NEBULA π π

A small planetary nebula, seen here below center, seems to be part of M46 but in fact lies in the foreground.